



THE FACTORY GAME STARTER GUIDE

Which game fits your brain, and how to avoid the
first 10 hours of mistakes

By Manu Games

The Assembly Line Newsletter

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The 2026 Snapshot

Factory games are built on one of the most addictive loops in gaming: gather resources, build machines, connect everything into automated production lines, and watch the whole thing hum. What starts as hand-mining ore becomes a symphony of conveyor belts, robotic arms, and logistics networks that run while you sleep.

If you're reading this, you probably already feel the pull. Maybe you've played one and want to find the next. Maybe a friend won't shut up about Factorio. Either way, this guide cuts through the noise and tells you **which game to play first, which one to play next**, and the five mistakes every new builder makes.

Why right now is a great time to start

Spring 2026 is one of the busiest update windows the genre has ever seen. Five of the biggest factory games shipped major content in the last 60 days:

Date	Game	What shipped
Apr 28, 2026	Foundry — Update 4 "Rails & Reactors"	Trains, 360 MW Xeno Power Plant, drones.
Apr 23, 2026	Shapez 2 — 1.0 release	Manufacture Mode, Steam Workshop, 86 achievements.
Apr 15, 2026	Mindustry — v8 stable	Multi-year rebuild lands on PC, Android, iOS.
Apr 2, 2026	Modulus: Factory Automation — 1.0	New entrant — 90%+ at launch.
Mar 17, 2026	Satisfactory — 1.2 Experimental	Vehicle automation, fluid trucks, weather.
Mar 9, 2026	Captain of Industry — Update 4 + Trains	Trains, map search, faster bridge loading.

Translation: anything you buy or download in the next month gets the biggest, freshest version of that game. Now is genuinely the best time to start.

The Genre, Mapped

"Factory games" is a label that covers four different fantasies. Pick the one that matches what you actually want to do.

1. Logistics & Automation (top-down)

The classic. You see your factory from above, design belt layouts, manage production ratios, and scale from a handful of machines to a megabase spanning thousands of tiles. Factorio wrote the playbook. Dyson Sphere Program put it in space. Mindustry put it under siege.

Key games: Factorio, Dyson Sphere Program, Mindustry

2. 3D Building & Exploration (first-person)

You walk through your factory and build it in three dimensions. These games add verticality, open-world exploration, and a sense of architectural scale that top-down games can't match. Your factory isn't a diagram — it's a place.

Key games: Satisfactory, Foundry, Captain of Industry, StarRupture, Stationeers

3. Abstract & Puzzle (shape-based)

Strip away the combat and resource gathering. Focus purely on routing shapes through machines — cutting, painting, stacking. These are factory games for people who love logic puzzles and don't need enemies to stay motivated.

Key games: Shaperez 2, Beltmatic

4. Factory + Twist (the new wave)

2025 and 2026 produced two real new sub-genres. **Factory roguelikes** (Rogue Factory, ShapeHero Factory) replay a single run with new modifiers. **Programmable factories** (Kaizen, The Farmer Was Replaced, Bitburner) ask you to write logic, not place belts. **Falling-sand factories** (Sandustry) and **cooking factories** (Snacktorio) prove the formula still has new shapes left to find.

Key games: Sandustry, Kaizen, Snacktorio, Rogue Factory, ShapeHero Factory

The Comparison Matrix

Six games, head-to-head. All prices are base Steam US prices as of April 2026. "Time to click" is how long until the loop genuinely grabs you — not when you'll finish.

Game	Complexity	Curve	Co-op	Mods	Click	Price
Factorio + Space Age	Very high	Steep but rewarding	Co-op (any)	Massive (~8K mods)	2–3 hrs	\$35 (+\$35 DLC)
Satisfactory	High	Moderate	Co-op (1–16)	1.2K mods (manager)	1–2 hrs	\$40
Shapez 2 (1.0)	Medium	Gentle	Solo	Workshop (new)	30 min	\$30
Dyson Sphere Program	High	Moderate–steep	Solo	Nexus mods	2–3 hrs	\$20
Foundry (EA — Update 4)	Medium–high	Moderate	Co-op (1–8)	Limited (EA)	1–2 hrs	\$30
Captain of Industry	Very high	Steep	Solo	Workshop	3–4 hrs	\$30

Mod numbers are pulled from each game's primary mod platform, April 2026. Wishlist anything that catches your eye — Steam summer sale routinely hits 30–40% on most of these.

One game on the watch list

StarRupture (Creepy Jar / January 2026 EA) is the biggest factory launch of 2026 — 500K+ pre-launch wishlists, 82% Very Positive at ~6,000 reviews, with a Coffee Stain crossover bundle already live. First-person, open-world, automation-between-alien-hordes. If you only buy one new factory game this year, this is the one to watch.

Play This If...

Factorio

You want the deepest factory experience ever made and you're not afraid of a learning curve. The Space Age expansion adds four new planets, each with unique resources and mechanics. This is the game every other factory game measures itself against. You'll lose weekends to it. Wube is in maintenance mode — a 2.1 update with QoL polish is on the horizon.

Satisfactory

You want to walk through your factory, admire what you built, and explore an open world between builds. Best-in-class multiplayer. Update 1.2 is in experimental on PC right now and adds vehicle automation, fluid trucks, and weather. PS5 / Xbox Series X|S available.

Shapedz 2

You want the puzzle without the survival. No enemies, no resource scarcity — just pure shape-routing logic. The 1.0 release shipped April 23, 2026 with the new Manufacture Mode for long-term factory building and full Steam Workshop support. Best entry-point in the genre.

Dyson Sphere Program

You want Factorio-depth with jaw-dropping visuals. Building a Dyson sphere around a star is one of the most satisfying endgames in the genre. Interplanetary logistics add a scale nothing else matches. Vehicle System and Space Stations are in active development for 2026.

Foundry

You want first-person building with the freedom to reshape the entire terrain. Dig, tunnel, terraform — the voxel world is yours. Published by Channel 3 / Paradox. Update 4 "Rails & Reactors" ships April 28, 2026 — trains and a 360 MW Xeno Power Plant. Great for creative builders.

Captain of Industry

You want factory building plus colony management. People, farming, terrain reshaping, vehicle logistics — all layered on top of the factory loop. The most complex game on this list. Think Factorio meets a city builder. The dev team confirmed 2–4 more years of Early Access in April 2026, so expect ongoing depth.

The 5 Mistakes Every New Player Makes

Every factory veteran made these mistakes. Learn from our collective pain.

Mistake #1 — Planning the "perfect" factory first

Your first factory will be spaghetti. Belts crossing, machines crammed at weird angles, nothing properly ratio'd. That's not a problem — it's the correct way to learn.

Perfection kills momentum. Your first factory teaches you what each building does and how resources flow. Trying to plan the perfect layout before you understand the recipes is like writing an outline before you know the topic. Embrace the mess. Build ugly. Tear it down and rebuild.

Mistake #2 — Ignoring the main bus

At some point your spaghetti hits a wall. Resources can't reach where they need to go. The main bus is the fix: a wide highway of belts running through your base carrying your most-used resources, with branches off to feed production areas.

In Satisfactory, use modular pods with conveyor lifts. In Shapez 2, the principle becomes routing logic. The principle is universal: separate production, connect with a clear transport system. You don't need to learn this before your first game — just know the concept exists so you recognize when you need it.

Mistake #3 — Guessing at production ratios

If one smelter makes 1 plate/sec and your assembler needs 2 plates/sec, you need two smelters. That's a production ratio, and ignoring them is the #1 cause of bottlenecks. Every factory game shows input/output rates. The math is usually simple: if Machine A outputs 30/min and Machine B needs 60/min, you need two of Machine A.

Most games have community ratio calculators (Factorio's Helmod, Satisfactory Tools, the DSP Calculator). Use them. If a belt is backing up or a machine is idle, you've got a ratio problem.

Mistake #4 — Too spread out, or too compact

New players either space everything a mile apart or cram it so tight there's no room to expand. Both hurt. Leave enough room between production areas to add one more row of machines. You'll almost always need to scale up. In 3D games, think vertically — stackable floors and conveyor lifts let you build up instead of out.

Rule of thumb: 2–3 tiles of buffer around each production cluster. Twice what you think you need.

Mistake #5 — Doing things manually too long

Hand-crafting items, manually loading machines, running resources back and forth — it feels productive, but you're the bottleneck. The entire point is to automate yourself out of a job. Every time you catch yourself doing something repetitive, ask: can a machine do this? The answer is almost always yes.

Automate early, automate often. A slow automated line beats a fast manual one because it works while you're planning your next expansion.

The meta-mistake

Watching tutorials before you've played. Every game in this guide has a 20-hour optimization YouTube rabbit hole. **Don't go in.** Play 4–5 hours blind first — the game itself is the best teacher, and the discoveries you make are the genre's main pleasure. The tutorials will still be there once you understand what they're solving.

Your First Hour — Per-Game Crib Sheets

Six pocket recipes. Get past the cold-start moment, then learn the rest by doing.

Factorio

Goal: automate iron plates before you starve. **Steps:** 1) Place a burner mining drill on iron ore feeding directly into a stone furnace. 2) Output the plates onto a yellow belt running into a wooden chest. 3) Repeat for copper. 4) Hand-feed coal until you can automate that too. **Trap to avoid:** don't hand-feed furnaces longer than 5 minutes — set up coal-on-belt next.

Satisfactory

Goal: first Hub upgrade. **Steps:** 1) Build a Miner Mk.1 on iron ore. 2) Smelter for iron ingots. 3) Constructor for iron plates. 4) Run the plates back to the Hub. **Trap to avoid:** don't fight the verticality — build the Smelter elevated and gravity-feed plates downhill.

Shapedz 2 (1.0)

Goal: first delivered shape. **Steps:** 1) Extract a circle. 2) Run it into the hub. 3) Done — that was your tutorial. Then start Manufacture Mode and build a permanent recipe-based production line. **Trap to avoid:** trying to plan multi-layer space platforms in your first hour. Ground floor first.

Dyson Sphere Program

Goal: first research lab tier. **Steps:** 1) Mine iron + copper. 2) Smelters for ingots. 3) Tier 1 logistics belts. 4) Matrix Lab making blue science. **Trap to avoid:** ignoring oil too long. Plastic and graphene are mid-game gates and oil takes practice.

Foundry

Goal: first vertical production loop. **Steps:** 1) Iron ore in. 2) Crusher → Smelter → Iron Plate Press. 3) Stack the machines and use conveyor lifts to chain them. **Trap to avoid:** building horizontal like it's Satisfactory. Foundry rewards 4–6 floor towers.

Captain of Industry

Goal: stable food supply. **Steps:** 1) Wheat farm before you do *anything* factory-related. 2) Bakery. 3) Manual delivery to settlement. **Trap to avoid:** spending the first 90 minutes on iron and ignoring food. Settlers eat or revolt — no exceptions.

The Idle Game Companion — 2026 picks

Not everyone has 4 hours to sink into belt layouts. Idle and incremental games deliver that same progression high in sessions you can pick up and put down. Here's what's worth playing right now, weighted to recent releases the rest of the internet hasn't caught up to yet.

Synergism

Hand-drawn pixel-art prestige incremental — reset layers, ant cave, ascensions, hypercubes, ~500 achievements. **Just hit Steam** in February 2026 after 5+ years as a free browser staple.

Free (browser) · \$5 on Steam

The Farmer Was Replaced

Idle farming sim where you write Python-like scripts to automate a drone instead of clicking. 96% Overwhelmingly Positive; **200,000+ copies sold** post-1.0. "Miner Was Replaced" DLC announced.

\$10 on Steam · PC

Cauldron

Upgrade-heavy, minigame-centric turn-based RPG where exponential minigame grinding powers a witch's auto-battle party. **Frequently named 2025 idle GOTY**. Coverage from PC Gamer and GameSpot.

\$15 on Steam · PC

Nodebuster

Bullet-hell-meets-incremental hybrid with a sprawling node skill tree — **the namesake of the 2025–26 "nodebuster-likes" sub-genre**. 96% Overwhelmingly Positive. ~3 hours; perfect entry.

\$2–3 on Steam · PC

Digseum

A ~3-hour incremental about digging up relics and curating a museum. 97% Overwhelmingly Positive on ~7,600 reviews. The model citizen of the new "finite incremental" wave.

\$5 on Steam · PC

Melvor Idle

Train skills, fight monsters, manage inventory — all while idle. The genre's gold-standard premium model: free-to-start, \$9.99 unlock, \$4.99 expansions. Melvor 2 has a 2026 Steam EA target.

Free to start · PC, mobile, browser

The classics, briefly: **Cookie Clicker** (free / \$5; Switch 2 port coming 2026), **Antimatter Dimensions** (free; gold-standard prestige math), **NGU Idle**, **Realm Grinder**, **Bitburner**, and **Idle Slayer**. URLs in the Links section.

Inside Look — Tideward

Full disclosure: I'm building this one. Tideward is an idle RPG native on every Apple device that I've been working on for over two years through Manu Games LLC. Since this guide covers the games I'm most passionate about, it only feels right to pull back the curtain on the one I'm making.

What it is

A skill-based idle RPG where you train skills, fight monsters, and gather resources — all running in the background while you go about your day. Think the depth of a full RPG, compressed into an idle format that respects your time. **Twenty-plus trades** across active and passive play: Combat (melee / ranged / magic with Vigil, spellbooks, and Quarry tasks), Woodcutting, Fishing, Kindling, Cooking, Mining, Forging, Handicraft, Bowcraft, Inscription, Apothecary, Pilfering, Wayfaring, Stargazing, Farming, Binding, Alt Magic — plus Hearth and Bank management. Bronze through Dragon gear sets, each trade with its own progression path.

What makes it different

- **Built for Apple, not ported to it.** Pure SwiftUI for iPhone, iPad, Mac, Apple Watch, Apple TV, and Vision Pro. Native from day one — no web wrappers, no Unity, no cross-platform compromises.
- **Privacy-first, architecturally.** Zero third-party SDKs. No analytics, no attribution, no ad networks, no tracking. Saves sync through iCloud and nowhere else. Not a marketing claim — it's the build.
- **Real 24-hour offline progression.** A compressed simulation runs when you open the app — XP, items, even combat with food and death risk. Not a 2-hour AFK token.
- **Clean monetization.** Paid-up-front or a single unlock — no energy bars, no premium currency, no gacha pulls. The interface looks like it was designed in 2026, not 2015.
- **Competitive Race Mode (post-launch).** Seasonal races where everyone starts fresh and competes to hit milestones first — the idle genre's answer to Path of Exile leagues.

Current status

Active development with TestFlight builds going out to early testers through Discord. The core gameplay loop is working — skills, combat, equipment, offline progression — and the focus now is the launch feature list: passive items, combat consumables, achievements, leaderboards, and a completion book. Apple's LLC processing has been... an experience. But the business side is sorted, and the focus now is shipping a 1.0 that's worth your time.

Get early access

Newsletter subscribers get first access to Tideward TestFlight builds and a direct line to shape the game's development. Subscribe at blog.manugames.com or visit manugames.com for more.

Links

Every game and project mentioned in this guide, with direct links.

Factory games

- **Factorio** factorio.com
- **Factorio: Space Age** factorio.com/buy-space-age
- **Satisfactory** satisfactorygame.com
- **Shaped 2** shaped2.com
- **Dyson Sphere Program** store.steampowered.com/app/1366540
- **Foundry** paradoxinteractive.com/games/foundry
- **Captain of Industry** captain-of-industry.com
- **StarRupture** store.steampowered.com/app/1631270
- **Mindustry** mindustrygame.github.io

Idle & incremental games

- **Tideward** manugames.com
- **Synergism** synergism.cc
- **The Farmer Was Replaced** store.steampowered.com/app/2060160
- **Cauldron** store.steampowered.com/app/2619650
- **Nodebuster** store.steampowered.com/app/3047030
- **Digseum** store.steampowered.com/app/3361470
- **Melvor Idle** melvoridle.com
- **Cookie Clicker** orteil.dashnet.org/cookieclicker
- **Antimatter Dimensions** ivark.github.io/AntimatterDimensions
- **NGU Idle** store.steampowered.com/app/941460
- **Realm Grinder** store.steampowered.com/app/610080
- **Bitburner** store.steampowered.com/app/1812820
- **Idle Slayer** store.steampowered.com/app/1353000

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About The Assembly Line

The Assembly Line is a free weekly newsletter covering factory games, idle games, and everything in between. Every issue, you get:

- **The Conveyor** — the biggest factory game story of the week, with an opinionated take.
- **Patch Notes Roundup** — quick-hit updates for Factorio, Satisfactory, Shapez 2, Dyson Sphere Program, Foundry, Captain of Industry, and the under-covered indies.
- **The Idle Corner** — idle and incremental game news, new releases, and r/incremental_games favorites.
- **Fresh Off the Line** — new Early Access launches, announced release dates, and notable wishlist additions.
- **The Deep Dive (rotating)** — strategy guides, head-to-head comparisons, developer spotlights, and design teardowns.
- **Tideward Dev Log** — a development diary straight from the trenches of building a premium idle RPG for Apple platforms.

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A new issue every week. No spam. No fluff. Just factory and idle game news from someone who actually plays them.

Share this guide with someone hunting for their next game.

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